HomecareOS

2026 EDITION

The UK Home Care Software Buyer's Guide

A practical workbook for owners, registered managers and coordinators. How to choose a platform that fits your agency, satisfies your nation's regulator and protects your margins, with a scorecard you can take into every demo.

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www.homecareos.co.uk

START HERE

How to use this guide

Choosing home care software is one of the biggest operational decisions an agency makes. The platform you pick shapes how your coordinators build the rota, how your carers record what happened at a visit, how you evidence compliance to your regulator, and how quickly you get paid. Switching later is painful, so it pays to choose well the first time.

This guide is built to be used, not just read. Work through it in order, then take the scorecard and the vendor worksheet into your demos. By the end you will have a shortlist scored on the things that actually matter, rather than the things a sales team wants to show you.

Who this is for

- **Agency owners** weighing cost, growth and total spend over the next few years.
- **Registered managers** who have to evidence safe, effective care to a regulator.
- **Coordinators and schedulers** who will live in the rota every day.
- **New agencies** setting up for the first time, and established agencies thinking about switching.

How to work through it

1. Read the landscape section so you know the kind of vendor you are talking to.
2. Use the twelve point scorecard to rate each platform out of 24.
3. Apply the five question framework to cut a long list down to two or three.
4. Pressure test pricing with the total cost of ownership section.
5. Check four nation compliance if you operate, or plan to operate, in more than one UK nation.
6. Record your findings on the vendor comparison worksheet, then plan the switch with the implementation checklist.

> ONE RULE FOR EVERY DEMO
>
> Ask to trial the software with your own agency's data, on your own devices, before you sign anything. A polished sales demo tells you how the product looks. A hands on trial tells you how it feels at 7am on a Monday when a carer has called in sick and you have forty visits to cover.

THE MARKET IN 2026

The landscape, and the three kinds of vendor

The UK home care software market has three broad types of vendor. Most products you look at will sit clearly in one of them. Knowing which you are dealing with tells you a lot about how the product will behave, how it is priced, and how much of your time an implementation will take.

Archetype	What it looks like	Watch for
Legacy enterprise	Long established, feature rich, often built before smartphones. Deep functionality, but the interface and the mobile app can feel dated. Sold with a longer implementation and a heavier price tag.	Per user pricing that climbs as you grow, long minimum terms, paid modules for things newer products include as standard, and a mobile app carers find awkward.
Modern SaaS	Cleaner design, a proper mobile app, quicker to set up. Strong on scheduling and care records. This is where most agencies now land.	Depth in the corners that matter to you: controlled drugs on the eMAR, split funding on invoices, genuine offline working, four nation compliance rather than England only.
AI first challengers	Newer entrants building automation into the core: cover finding, rota building, risk scoring. Usually strong design and transparent pricing.	Track record and support. Ask how long they have been live, how many agencies use them, and what happens when you need a person on the phone.

None of these is automatically right or wrong. A small agency that wants to be live in a fortnight has very different needs from a fifty branch group with bespoke council contracts. The point is to know the type of vendor in front of you, so you can ask the right questions and read the price the right way.

Where does HomecareOS sit? We are a modern platform with AI built into the core, designed for all four UK nations from day one, with a genuinely offline mobile app. We tell you this up front so you can weigh what follows with your eyes open. Everything in this guide works whichever vendor you choose.

THE CENTREPIECE

The twelve point evaluation scorecard

Score each platform on these twelve points. Give **0** if it is missing or weak, **1** if it is present but partial, and **2** if it is genuinely strong. Add the column for a mark out of 24. As a rule of thumb, treat anything under 14 as a product that will fight you rather than help you.

#	What to check, and why it matters	Score (0 to 2)
1	**Scheduling engine.** Drag and drop rota, run templates, and clean handling of double up, shadow and spot check visits. This is where coordinators spend their day.	☐☐☐
2	**Four nation regulatory fit.** Does it support the regulator you actually answer to, not just CQC in England. Compliance templates should follow your nation.	☐☐☐
3	**Truly offline mobile app.** Carers work in homes with no signal. The app must let them check in, read the care plan and record notes offline, then sync later.	☐☐☐
4	**Pricing transparency.** A published price you can understand without a sales call, and a model that does not punish you for growing. See the pricing section.	☐☐☐
5	**eMAR depth.** Electronic medication records that handle controlled drugs, as required doses, refusals and variable doses, not just a simple tick list.	☐☐☐
6	**Family portal that gets used.** Relatives can see visit confirmations, who is coming and care summaries. This cuts office phone calls and builds trust.	☐☐☐
7	**Wellbeing and retention signals.** Does it surface staff churn risk, absence patterns and measures such as the Bradford Factor. Retention is a margin issue.	☐☐☐
8	**Hands on trial.** Can you try it with your own data, on your own phones, without a gatekeeping sales process. If not, ask why.	☐☐☐
9	**Data migration.** What will they actually import: service users, carers, care plans, medication, historic visits. Get the list in writing.	☐☐☐
10	**Contract flexibility.** Minimum term, notice period and what happens to your data if you leave. Long lock ins are a warning sign.	☐☐☐
11	**Support that answers.** A named channel, published response times and real people. Ask how support is delivered during your first month.	☐☐☐
12	**Integrations.** Payroll, accounts, telephony and any eMAR or pharmacy partners you rely on. Check the ones you need exist today, not on a roadmap.	☐☐☐

READING YOUR SCORE

20 to 24 a strong fit, shortlist it. **14 to 19** workable, but be clear on where it is weak and whether that matters to you. **Below 14** likely to cause friction every day, think hard before signing.

CUT THE LIST DOWN

The five question decision framework

The scorecard rates each product. These five questions cut a long list down to the two or three worth trialling properly. Any one of them can rule a vendor out on its own.

1. **Which UK nations do you operate in, now and in the next two years?**
If you work in Wales, Scotland or Northern Ireland, an England only product will not evidence compliance for your regulator. This is often the fastest way to shorten a list.

2. **What does the pricing model count, and what happens as you grow?**
A price that looks fine at twenty staff can double at fifty. Ask exactly what is metered: every user, only carers, office staff too. Model it at the size you expect to be, not the size you are.

3. **Does the mobile app genuinely work offline?**
Ask for a live demonstration with the phone in aeroplane mode. Check in, open a care plan, write a note. If any of that fails without signal, your carers will feel it every day.

4. **Can you trial it with your own data before you commit?**
A vendor confident in the product will let you. If a trial is only ever a scripted demo on their data, treat that as information.

5. **What is the minimum term, and how do you get your data out?**
Understand the exit before you sign the entry. A short term and a clean data export are signs of a vendor that expects to keep you by being good, not by locking you in.

FOLLOW THE MONEY

Pricing models and total cost of ownership

The headline price is rarely the real price. To compare vendors fairly, look at the total cost of ownership over the first two or three years, not the monthly figure on the pricing page.

What the price actually counts

The single biggest variable is what a vendor calls a user. Some charge for every account, including office coordinators and managers who never attend a visit. Others charge only for the carers who deliver care. On a real rota that difference is large, and it grows as you add office capacity.

THE HOMECAREOS APPROACH

We price per active carer and leave office logins unmetered. Coordinators, managers and administrators do not add to the bill. You pay for the people delivering care, not for the people organising it. There is also a free tier for the smallest agencies, so a new agency can start without a software bill on day one.

The costs that hide below the headline

- **Implementation and setup fees.** One off charges for onboarding, data migration and training. Ask for the figure in writing.
- **Paid modules.** Features that sound standard but sit behind an upgrade: eMAR, family portal, finance, reporting.
- **Seat creep.** Under a per user model, every new office hire adds to the monthly cost, not just every new carer.
- **Support tiers.** Faster response times sometimes cost extra. Check what the standard tier actually includes.
- **Exit costs.** Charges to export your data, or the cost of running two systems in parallel during a switch.

A simple way to compare

Build the same three year total for every vendor on your shortlist. Use your expected headcount, not today's, and include every line below. The cheapest monthly price often is not the cheapest platform once the full picture is on one page.

Cost line	Per user platform	Per active carer
Monthly licence, all staff who need a login	Counts every account	Counts carers only
Office and coordinator logins	Usually chargeable	Typically unmetered
Implementation and migration	Confirm in writing	Confirm in writing
Modules (eMAR, family, finance)	Often extra	Check what is included
Cost as you grow the office	Rises with every hire	Flat for office roles

Illustrative structure only. Fill in each vendor's real figures on the worksheet before you compare.

COMPLIANCE IS NOT ONE SIZE FITS ALL

Four nation compliance requirements

Home care is regulated separately in each UK nation. The regulator, the background check, the workforce register and the evidence framework all differ. If your software was built for England only, it will not map cleanly onto the others. Use this table to check that any platform you consider supports the nation you actually operate in.

Nation	Regulator	Background check	Workforce register
England	Care Quality Commission (CQC)	DBS check	No single register. Care Certificate expected
Wales	Care Inspectorate Wales (CIW)	DBS check	Social Care Wales (SCW)
Scotland	Care Inspectorate	PVG scheme membership	Scottish Social Services Council (SSSC)
Northern Ireland	RQIA	AccessNI check	Northern Ireland Social Care Council (NISCC)

WHAT TO ASK THE VENDOR

Does the platform record the right background check and registration type for my nation automatically, and does it flag expiry before it lapses. A product that only knows about DBS and CQC will quietly create compliance gaps in the other three nations.

If you operate across more than one nation, this matters even more. You need a single platform that applies the correct framework per branch, rather than bending an England only tool to fit. HomecareOS treats the nation as a core setting that drives compliance templates, the background check type and the registration body for every carer.

BRING THIS TO YOUR DEMOS

Vendor comparison worksheet

Fill in a column for each shortlisted vendor as you go. Bring the completed sheet to your decision meeting. Seeing three products side by side on one page makes the right choice far clearer than remembering three separate demos.

Question	Vendor A	Vendor B	Vendor C
Scorecard total (out of 24)			
Supports my nation's regulator			
What the price counts (users or carers)			
Three year total cost			
Genuinely offline mobile app			
Trial with our own data offered			
Implementation and migration cost			
Minimum term and notice period			
Data export on exit			
Integrations we need, live today			
Support channel and response time			
Our overall confidence (high, medium, low)			

FROM DECISION TO GO LIVE

Implementation and migration checklist

The right software badly rolled out still fails. Once you have chosen, work through this checklist so the switch is calm rather than chaotic. Agree the plan and the owner for each step with your vendor before you start.

Before you migrate

- [ ] Agree exactly what data will be migrated, and what will not, in writing.
- [ ] Clean your current data first: remove duplicates, close inactive service users, tidy carer records.
- [ ] Confirm a named implementation contact on the vendor side and a project owner on yours.
- [ ] Set a realistic go live date that avoids month end payroll and invoicing.

During the switch

- [ ] Run a parallel period where the old and new systems overlap, so nothing is lost in the gap.
- [ ] Train coordinators first, then carers, with short hands on sessions rather than long slide decks.
- [ ] Test one full pay run and one full invoice run in the new system before you rely on it.
- [ ] Check the mobile app on real carer phones, including older devices and poor signal areas.

After go live

- [ ] Keep read access to the old system for a few months in case you need historic records.
- [ ] Book a review with the vendor at thirty days to fix the friction the team has found.
- [ ] Collect carer feedback early: they will tell you what works long before the office notices.

THE PLATFORM BEHIND THIS GUIDE

About HomecareOS

HomecareOS is a home care management platform built for UK agencies across all four nations. We wrote this guide because we believe an informed buyer makes a better decision, whichever product they choose. Here is where we fit against the questions above.

What we do differently

- Built for CQC, CIW, Care Inspectorate and RQIA from day one
- AI cover finder that scores available carers when someone calls in sick
- A genuinely offline mobile app for field carers
- eMAR, care records, scheduling, compliance and finance in one place

How we price

- Per active carer, with office logins and service users unmetered
- Free for your first 5 carers, no time limit and no credit card
- Then Pro at £10 per active carer per month
- Clear terms and your data exportable if you leave

Ready to see it, or just want to talk it through? Try the platform, or book a straightforward conversation with no sales pressure.

www.homecareos.co.uk